

Discussion of de Jong and Jaziri Arjona

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June 26, 2025

Summary and contribution

Theoretical argument: The social networks in which lower education are embedded – specifically whether they contain individuals with tertiary education – moderate their responses to economic insecurity → helps explain variation in support for radical-right parties (RRP) among these voters

Empirical contribution: Triangulation of different data sources and between observational as well as experimental strategies to test the argument

- China shock (US), 2022
- Panel data (Netherlands), 2008 to 2012
- Experiment (Germany), 2025

Three comments: Tighten framing, clarify theoretical intuitions, and sharpen focus of empirical analysis.

Comment #1: The current framing is too non-committal, thus underplaying the paper's contributions

The introduction could do with sharper focus. Is this a paper primarily about economic insecurity and RRP support? Or, is this paper about social networks and their political effects?

Here is my suggestion:

Lower-educated voters are an important constituency of radical right parties. Yet, they are not a homogenous bloc. Despite that, our understanding of what explains the variation in their responses to economic shocks remains severely limited. In this paper, we argue that the social networks in which these individuals are embedded – specifically whether lower educated individuals' networks contain individuals with tertiary education – moderate their responses, helping shed light on the variation we observe among this group of voters.

Comment #2: The theoretical intuitions need to be spelt out more sharply

[Economic buffer mechanism requires more reflection](#). In principle, it is plausible that ties to high-education individuals reduce the effective economic insecurity faced by low-education individuals, but ...

- Is this all that relevant in mature welfare states? If so, provide more evidence.
- The correlation between income and education has decreased in recent decades (Gethin, Martínez-Toledano, and Piketty, [2022](#); Kitschelt and Rehm, [2023](#)).
- Why would lower insecurity lead to lower RRP support? More detailed engagement with the literature would be helpful (Guiso et al., [2024](#); Guriev and Papaioannou, [2022](#))

You briefly discuss two additional channels – [the informational and other-regarding one](#). To me, they seem to be mostly relevant for high-education individuals, but your empirical analysis focuses mostly on the lower-education ones → either expand analysis or keep theoretical discussion tightly focused

Theorising norm diffusion across social networks

Most exciting intuition: Norms against support RRP diffuse across networks, thus blunting the effect of economic insecurity on RRP support. Explicate this intuition more clearly.

- To flesh out your argument, you need to discuss why low-education individuals would accept the norms promoted by their high-education 'buddies'. Sorting? Persuasion? If the latter, why (see Druckman, 2022)?
- In developing this justification, you might also want to draw on related works (Apffelstaedt, Freundt, and Oslislo, 2022; Lindskog et al., 2024) and the extensive social science literature on norm diffusion (Binmore, 2022; Gintis, 2010; Levine and Mattozzi, 2020; Young, 2015, 2024).

Consideration of alternative mechanism: Social networks and their effect on reference points and social comparisons.

Comment #3: Walking the tightrope between triangulation and a kitchen-sink approach

Generally speaking, there is much to like about the empirical section. That said, the section strikes me as over-loaded. As a result, there is too little detail on the individual studies in the main body.

- For each study, I'd like to see descriptives on the social network composition variable.
- How much value does the China shock analysis add?
- I'd like to see more justification of the experimental treatment, particularly with respect to the theoretical discussion.
- More careful discussion of the identifying variation you use for your panel analysis and why it corresponds to your theoretical quantity of interest.

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